Version accessible

Passing the Flame. Othello: ten autonomous fiches, one for each lesson, usable on their own.

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Specialism LLCER English · Terminale of the lycée général et technologique

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Théodore Chassériau, Othello et Desdémone à Venise, 1849-1850, oil on wood, Musée du Louvre, Paris, RF 3897, public domain.

Guiding question

How does Shakespeare turn theatre itself into a trap of perception in Othello, and what does that trap still teach us about language, jealousy and the courage to read between the lines?

conçu par Madame Carole Paoli Pompougnac, mis en page par Grok

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An accessible C1 booklet for the sequence *Passing the Flame* (*Othello*). Spécialité LLCER anglais, Terminale of the lycée général et technologique. This version can be used on its own. It keeps the same guiding question, the same ten lessons, and the same public-domain text. Layout is clearer, tasks are shorter, and each step is numbered. The intellectual demand is not lowered to another programme.

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Guiding question. How does Shakespeare turn theatre itself into a trap of perception in *Othello*, and what does that trap still teach us about language, jealousy and the courage to read between the lines?

How to use this booklet.

- One lesson at a time. Read the aim. Then do the tasks in order.

- Quotations follow a public-domain text (Project Gutenberg ebook 1531). In class you may align line numbers with the Folger Digital Text.
- Each lesson lasts 55 minutes, timed on 52. At minute 44, stop and gather one claim. The last eight minutes are an emergency exit if you need a shorter close.
- Vocabulary headings are called **Building your vocabulary**.
- The method is the spirale de Gorse (the French name is kept). Méthode de la spirale de Gorse conçue par Madame Carole Paoli Pompougnac.

The tip of the spiral. When a society believes images and rumours rather than facts and persons, who becomes the victim, and why?

Fiche autonome 1. Inheriting a way of reading

Aim. To watch, to look, and to write one precise diagnostic.

Turn 1. Can we trust what we see?

Task 1. Watch the video essay once, without notes. Then write one sentence: is the voice remembering, teaching, or both?

Task 2. Watch again. Complete:

- A person who is named: …
- A gesture that is remembered: …
- One idea you attach to « reading between the lines »: …

Task 3. Look at Chassériau, *Othello et Desdémone à Venise*, 1849-1850, Louvre RF 3897, public domain. Write three observations. Each one must mention a pictorial fact (a gesture, a gaze, a light, a space between figures). Do not retell the plot.

Task 4. Written record (about 120 words). What does it mean, in the theatre, to read between the lines? Why can that courage also be dangerous? Distinguish, if you can, seeing, interpreting and knowing.

Emergency exit. Three sentences: one fact, one inference, one question you keep open.

Building your vocabulary. homage; transmission; subtext; spectator; theatrical illusion; to pass on a way of reading.

Homework. Read I.1 up to « I am not what I am ». Learn the last lines, from « For when my outward action » to the end of the speech.

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Fiche autonome 2. « I am not what I am »

Aim. To read Iago's line as a contract with the spectator.

Turn 2. Why tell an audience you are not what you seem?

The lines (public-domain text).

> *For when my outward action doth demonstrate*
> *The native act and figure of my heart*
> *In complement extern, 'tis not long after*
> *But I will wear my heart upon my sleeve*
> *For daws to peck at: I am not what I am.*

Task 1. Recite. Mark the stresses you hear.

Task 2. Answer, in short sentences:

1. What does it mean, here, to wear one's heart on one's sleeve?
2. Why does Iago refuse that image?
3. Who, besides Roderigo, hears « I am not what I am »?
4. What privilege does the spectator now have?
5. Is that privilege safe? Why, or why not?

Task 3. Written record (about 120 words). How is this line a contract with the audience?

Emergency exit. Paraphrase the line; name the spectator's privilege; ask whether it is safe.

Building your vocabulary. to profess; outward; to wear one's heart on one's sleeve; accomplice; dramatic irony.

Homework. Read Othello's tale in I.3, from « Her father lov'd me » to « This only is the witchcraft I have us'd », and Brabantio's warning.

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Fiche autonome 3. The Senate

Aim. To see how a story wins a hearing, and what a father tries to plant.

Turn 3. How does a story about oneself win a hearing?

Three quotations to keep on the page.

She lov'd me for the dangers I had pass'd,
And I lov'd her that she did pity them.
This only is the witchcraft I have us'd.

I saw Othello's visage in his mind.

Look to her, Moor, if thou hast eyes to see:
She has deceiv'd her father, and may thee.

My life upon her faith! Honest Iago,
My Desdemona must I leave to thee.

Task 1. In the first quotation, draw the crossing of terms (who loves, and for what?). This crossing is a chiasmus.

Task 2. In one sentence, what kind of seeing is « I saw Othello's visage in his mind »?

Task 3. Why are the words « eyes to see », in Brabantio's warning, already dangerous in a play about looking?

Task 4. What is pledged in « My life upon her faith », and what dramaturgical error follows at once?

Task 5. Written record (about 150 words). How does Othello turn his life into a story a court can hear, and what does Brabantio plant in the same hearing?

Emergency exit. Copy the four quotations. Add one sentence on public trust.

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Building your vocabulary. testimony; visage; to plant a warning; pledge; witchcraft (here, sarcastic).

Homework. Read III.3, including the green-eyed monster, « Haply, for I am black », and « ocular proof ».

Fiche autonome 4. The desire for proof

Aim. To understand how a wish to know becomes a wish to be confirmed.

Turn 4. When does a demand for proof become a wish to be confirmed?

Task 1. Who speaks of the « green-ey'd monster », to whom, and why may a warning also be a suggestion?

Task 2. Read « Haply, for I am black ». What public language (from the Senate) returns here, now spoken by Othello about himself?

Task 3. Define *ocular proof* in one precise sentence. Then add a second sentence: why is this demand reasonable, and why is it fatal in a theatre?

Task 4. Written record (about 150 words). In III.3, how does Shakespeare turn the wish to know into a wish to be confirmed?

Emergency exit. A six-line commentary on the phrase « ocular proof » only.

Building your vocabulary. jealousy; ocular proof; to interiorise; insinuation; free and open nature.

Homework. Read all of III.4 twice. Learn from « Give me your hand » to « our new heraldry is hands, not hearts ».

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Fiche autonome 5. The handkerchief and the test of trust

Aim. To close-read III.4: Emilia's silence, the moist hand, the history of the handkerchief, the change of subject, the theme of trust.

Turn 5. Who decides what a gift is allowed to mean?

Work in this order. Do not skip.

Step 1. Emilia. Desdemona asks where the handkerchief is. Emilia says, « I know not, madam. » The audience knows she has it. Why is this both a lie and a silence? What does Desdemona still believe about her husband's mind?

Step 2. The moist hand.

> *Give me your hand. This hand is moist, my lady.*
>
> *[…]*
>
> *This argues fruitfulness and liberal heart.*
>
> *Hot, hot, and moist. […]*
>
> *For here's a young and sweating devil here*
>
> *That commonly rebels. 'Tis a good hand,*
>
> *A frank one.*
>
> *[…]*
>
> *The hearts of old gave hands,*
>
> *But our new heraldry is hands, not hearts.*

Answer:

1. What physical fact does Othello start from?
2. What moral meaning does he add?
3. How does Desdemona explain the same hand (« 'twas that hand that gave away my heart »)?
4. What does the sentence about heraldry mean, and how is it used against her?

Step 3. The history of the handkerchief. An Egyptian charmer, a sibyl, « magic in the web », perdition if the gift is lost. Choose, with one piece of evidence, among three possibilities: a family story told in good faith; a story used to intimidate; a mixture of the two. The play may not settle this. You may say so, if you argue it.

Step 4. Change of subject. Desdemona says, « Come now, your promise », and speaks of Cassio. She also says, « It is not lost, but what and if it were? » Why is a hypothetical dangerous here?

Step 5. Emilia at the end. She says jealous souls are « jealous for they are jealous », and that jealousy is a monster « Begot upon itself ». What does she understand? What does she still not say?

Written record (about 180 words). In III.4, how does Shakespeare test, and then unmake, three kinds of trust? (Othello’s trust in Desdemona; Desdemona’s trust that truth will be enough; Emilia’s trust that silence can serve two loyalties.)

Emergency exit. Four short moves: Emilia’s lie; one sentence from the moist-hand speech; « magic in the web »; « jealous for they are jealous ». Then one sentence on trust.

Building your vocabulary. to dissemble; heraldry; charmer; sibyl; perdition; to over-read; self-begotten.

Homework. Fair copy of the written record. Read IV.1, the moment when Othello watches Iago and Cassio. Prepare the midpoint commentary: « In Act III, scene 4, how does Shakespeare make a hand, a handkerchief and a change of subject into instruments of a trap of perception? »

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Fiche autonome 6. Directing the spectator

Aim. To see IV.1 as a scene directed from inside the play.

Turn 6. How can a scene be directed before anyone speaks?

Task 1. Complete the table.

Role in the inner theatre	Character	What this person knows
Director		
Spectator		
Unwitting actor		

Task 2. What has Iago told Othello the coming scene will mean, before it is played?

Task 3. Written record (about 150 words). How does Shakespeare make Othello a spectator of his own deception? (This question returns in Lesson 10.)

Emergency exit. Three columns: *What Othello sees*; *What he has been told he will see*; *What the audience knows*. Five facts, then one concluding sentence.

Building your vocabulary. mise en scène; to withdraw; to overhear; spectacle; to construe.

Homework. Read the Bianca episode in IV.1.

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Fiche autonome 7. One conversation, two meanings

Aim. To show that the same words can carry two referents.

Turn 7. Can two people share a conversation and not share its meaning?

Task 1. Fill the table. At least three rows.

Moment	What is actually being said	What Othello is made to hear
Bianca enters		
The handkerchief is shown		
A laugh, or a dismissive word		

Task 2. The handkerchief has already been a love-token (early in the play) and a magical warrant (III.4). What third meaning does it receive here (a « work » to be copied)?

Task 3. Written record (about 120 words). How can one conversation carry two meanings, and what does that do to the idea of ocular proof?

Emergency exit. Three completed rows and this sentence, which you may use: seeing is not proving when the story has been assigned in advance.

Building your vocabulary. referent; assigned meaning; token; pattern; dramatic irony.

Homework. Read V.2, the « Put out the light » speech and the last speech (« Speak of me as I am »). Learn the doubled line about the light.

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Fiche autonome 8. The language of justification

Aim. To read a murder that tries to sound like justice, and a last speech that tries to direct a future report.

Turn 8. How can murder be made to sound like justice?

Task 1.

> *Put out the light, and then put out the light.*

- What is the first light?
- What is the second light?
- What device is this (a word repeated and turned)?

Task 2. In the last speech, Othello says: « Speak of me as I am. Nothing extenuate, / Nor set down aught in malice. » Who is he addressing? What story does he still wish to control?

Task 3. Some editions read « the base Judean », others « the base Indian » (Gutenberg 1531 reads « Judean »). This is a crux: a place where the text is unsettled. You are not asked to settle it. You are asked to say, in one sentence, why honesty requires the uncertainty.

Task 4. Written record (about 150 words). In V.2, how do a language of justice and a language of love occupy the same lines?

Emergency exit. Quote the doubled « light »; paraphrase it; quote « Speak of me as I am »; one sentence on a last attempt to direct a spectator.

Building your vocabulary. to justify; to sacralise; to extenuate; pearl; crux; report.

Homework. Read the short critics' notices in the main booklet (or the summaries your teacher gives). Prepare to answer one critic.

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Fiche autonome 9. What can literature teach?

Aim. To answer a public-domain critic, and to look at one translation choice by François-Victor Hugo.

Turn 9. Does literature educate judgement, or only show its limits?

Task 1. Choose one critic. Complete:

- Name and work:
- One thing he sees:
- One thing he misses, or one way you resist him:
- A line from *Othello* that answers him:

Help:

- Rymer (1693) mocks the handkerchief and treats the play as, in substance, a bloody farce. You can answer him with Lesson 5: the cloth is not the cause, it is the object of a forced reading.
- Johnson (1765) opposes Othello's « fiery openness » to Iago's « cool malignity ». Test the word *credulous*.
- Coleridge speaks of « the motive-hunting of a motiveless malignity ». Use the phrase, then ask whether the hunt for motives is itself a performance.
- Hazlitt attends to Iago's intellect. Can we describe that intelligence without admiring the harm?
- Bradley (1904) calls Othello a « romantic » hero in a strong sense: a nature that lives at a height. Unpack the word.

Task 2. Hugo. Compare « I am not what I am » with François-Victor Hugo's public-domain French (the extract your teacher provides). In about 120 words, in English: what choice does Hugo make, and what happens to the theatrical contract of the line?

Emergency exit. One paragraph answering Rymer only.

Building your vocabulary. judgement; malignity; credulous; rendering; to resist a critic.

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Homework. Revise for Lesson 10. No new reading.

Fiche autonome 10. Explaining the trap

Aim. To write the summative commentary, and to speak a short director's note.

Turn 10. Can we explain the trap without being trapped by our own reading?

Written task. Commentary: « How does Shakespeare make Othello a spectator of his own deception? »

Use this skeleton if it helps, then make it your own:

1. **Introduction.** One precise thesis. You may say that Shakespeare first gives the *audience* a spectator's privilege (I.1), and later gives that privilege, corrupted, to Othello (IV.1).
2. **Part 1.** The training of looking: I.1, perhaps I.3 and III.3 or III.4, in brief and with quotations.
3. **Part 2.** IV.1 as a theatre inside the theatre: director, spectator, unwitting actor; two meanings in one conversation.
4. **Conclusion.** Return to the guiding question. Leave something unsettled if the play leaves it unsettled.

Stopping point, minute 44: you should have a thesis, one complete part, and a sketched close. Emergency exit: three tight movements (the pact of I.1; the staged looking of IV.1; one sentence of humility).

Oral task (two to three minutes). « If I were to direct one scene so that the trap of perception became visible, I would choose… » Name the scene. Justify one staging choice from the verse. Name one risk (simplifying, flattering the audience, making Iago charming).

The tip, if there is time. When a society believes images and rumours rather than facts and persons, who becomes the victim, and why? Answer in a few careful sentences, not with a wide claim. You may open one path: existential, political, or civilisational.

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Méthode de la spirale de Gorse conçue par Madame Carole Paoli Pompougnac.

Building your vocabulary (revision). spectator; deception; ocular proof; to over-read; mise en scène; judgement; humility.